

Family-Based Immigration Makes America Safer and Stronger

Family unity is the cornerstone of America’s immigration system for good reason: family reunification is deeply rooted in American values. But beyond the moral importance of family-based immigration, family reunification has positive effects on our communities. This factsheet specifically outlines how family-based immigration strengthens community well-being.

This factsheet was prepared by Asian Americans Advancing Justice | AAJC, a national nonprofit that advocates for an America in which all Americans can benefit equally from, and contribute to, the American dream. Our mission is to advance the civil and human rights of Asian Americans and to build and promote a fair and equitable society for all.

The growth in the Asian American population is intimately tied to the family-based immigration system. Once the racist laws that limited or excluded Asian Americans from immigrating in the 1800s and early 1900s¹ were changed to a primarily family-based system in the 1960s, the U.S. saw a rapid increase in immigration from Asia (along other historically underrepresented countries).² Today, there are about 13.3 million Asian immigrants in the U.S.,³ representing nearly one-third of the total immigration population.⁴ After Mexico, India, China, and the Philippines are the top countries of origin for immigrants.⁵

Family-Based Immigration Makes Up the Majority of Immigration to the U.S.

Much of the discourse around the benefits of immigration have focused on employment-based immigration, even though most immigrants who receive green cards—and thus become lawful permanent residents (LPRs)—are family-based immigrants.⁶

About 1 million green cards are issued in any given year.⁷ Of those, family-based immigration accounted for 63 percent of new LPRs in the United States over the past five years, with 47 percent of LPRs being immediate relatives of U.S. citizens.⁸

Type and class of admission	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
TOTAL	1,031,770	707,360	740,000	1,018,350	1,172,910
Immediate relatives of U.S. citizens	505,770	321,150	385,400	428,270	551,590
Family-sponsored preferences	204,140	121,560	65,690	166,040	204,240
Employment-based preferences	139,460	148,960	193,340	270,280	196,760
Diversity	43,460	25,030	15,150	43,230	67,350
Refugees	80,910	44,400	35,850	29,420	59,030
Asylees	26,000	19,470	20,550	53,660	40,330
All other	32,030	26,800	24,040	27,440	53,610

Source: 2023 Yearbook of Immigration Statistics, Department of Homeland Security

There have been some reports on the economic benefits of family-based immigration.⁹ This brief focuses instead on the social benefits of family-based immigration. Specifically, this brief outlines some of the social benefits of family-based immigration.

Historical data on crime rates shows that despite the growth of the immigrant population—primarily driven by family-based immigration—crime rates have dropped.¹⁰ Higher levels of immigration in recent decades have corresponded with a drop in U.S. crime rates.¹¹ In 1980, when immigrants made up 6.2% of the U.S. population, “the total crime rate was 5,900 crimes per 100,000 people. By 2022, the share of immigrants had more than doubled, to 13.9 percent, while the total crime rate had dropped by 60.4 percent, to 2,335 crimes per 100,000 people.”¹² A possible explanation for this may be related to how family-based immigration increases social cohesion.

1. Tight-Knit Communities are Safer Communities

Studies show that “neighborhood attachment (residents’ feeling of belonging to a neighborhood)” and social cohesion both enhance public safety and reduce crime rates.¹³ Social cohesion refers to “the togetherness or connectedness of a place”¹⁴ and is reflected in “the ability of neighborhoods to realize the common values of residents” and their “willingness to intervene on behalf of the common good.”¹⁵

2. Family-Based Immigration Increases Social Cohesion

Family-based immigration promotes social cohesion,¹⁶ because when families reunite and support one another, they create robust social networks and foster a sense of belonging, ultimately resulting in more stable, resilient, and safer communities.¹⁷

a. Families Serve as Largely Self-Sufficient Integration Networks

One way family-based immigration increases social cohesion is through the creation of kinship networks, which serve as largely self-sufficient integration networks.¹⁸ Kinship networks can provide practical assistance and support the social wellbeing of new arrivals. Immigrant communities are often built around family ties, helping newcomers find housing and employment, and understand local customs.¹⁹ These networks are pivotal in creating strong and resilient communities, which in turn creates safer communities

b. Family-based Immigration Strengthens Social Networks

Strong family networks create a sense of solidarity among community members, which fosters strong interpersonal connections and collective identity, instilling a sense of solidarity among community members.²⁰ Immigrants are often active participants in community activities and civic engagement, and they engage in political action to address community concerns.²¹

3. Strong Family Networks Promote Better Mental Health Outcomes

Family-based immigration also provides a source of community support, which is associated with better mental health.²² In fact, preserving and rebuilding immigrant families “may indirectly improve the health and well-being of the entire US [sic] population.”²³ Those facing extreme hardships or fleeing traumatic situations are at a higher risk of experiencing mental health challenges including post-traumatic stress disorder.²⁴ Family unity can serve as a bulwark, providing support to help address these challenges.²⁵

As one example, a study focusing on Chinese and Korean American immigrants found that adequate social support lowers “perceived stress and distress, leading to better overall health.”²⁶ The United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees emphasizes that early social support can “reduce anxiety and assist resettled refugees to gain a sense of control and independence.” Moreover, they urge that resettled refugees being placed close to family members are a “vital resource in the integration process.”²⁷

4. We Need Reforms to the Family-Based Immigration System, Not Cuts

Family immigration has served our country well, but after decades without change, the system is in dire need of updating. Due to categorical and country-based caps on family-based visas as well as technical issues with how the number of visas is calculated, a massive and growing backlog for family-based visas has built up over time. Spouses, siblings, children, and their parents are forced to live apart for years and often decades.

Instead of attacking a system that is deeply connected to the American identity and that has had positive social effects for decades, policy-makers should turn their attention to addressing the inefficiencies in our family-based immigration system.

1. "Anti-Asian Laws and Policies," (U.S. National Park Service, May 27, 2025), <https://www.nps.gov/articles/000/anti-asian-laws-and-policies.htm>.
2. Muzaffar Chishti, Faye Hipsman, and Isabel Ball, "Fifty Years On, the 1965 Immigration and Nationality Act Continues to Reshape the United States," Migration Information Source (Migration Policy Institute, October 15, 2015), <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/fifty-years-1965-immigration-and-nationality-act-continues-reshape-united-states>.
3. "S0201 Selected Population Profile in the United States," American Community Survey, ACS 1-Year Estimates Selected Population Profiles, U.S. Census Bureau, 2023, accessed February 4, 2025, <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSSPPIY2023.S0201?t=031>.
4. Alejandro Urbina-Bernal and Jeanne Batalova, "Immigrants from Asia in the United States," Migration Information Source (Washington, D.C.: Migration Policy Institute, April 17, 2025), <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/immigrants-asia-united-states>.
5. Urbina-Bernal and Batalova, "Immigrants from Asia in the United States."
6. Jeanne Batalova, "Frequently Requested Statistics on Immigrants and Immigration in the United States," Migration Information Source (Washington, D.C.: Migration Policy Institute, March 12, 2025), <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/frequently-requested-statistics-immigrants-and-immigration-united-states>.
7. Alicia Ward, "U.S. Lawful Permanent Residents: 2023," (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics, September 2024), https://ohss.dhs.gov/sites/default/files/2024-09/2024_0906_plcy_lawful_permanent_residents_fy2023.pdf.
8. "Table 6. Persons Obtaining Lawful Permanent Resident Status by Type and Major Class of Admission: Fiscal Years 2014 to 2023," (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics, September 2024), <https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook-immigration-statistics/yearbook-2023>.
9. "The Advantages of Family-Based Immigration," Fact Sheet (Washington, D.C.: American Immigration Council, March 2023), <https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/fact-sheet/advantages-family-based-immigration/>.
10. As Robert J. Sampson notes in his work on the relationship between crime and immigration, "correlation doesn't equal causation. But it does demonstrate the trends are opposite of what's commonly assumed, which is surely not irrelevant to the many, and strongly causal, claims that immigration increase crime." Robert J. Sampson, "Rethinking Crime and Immigration," *Contexts* 7, no. 1 (February 2008): 28–33, <https://doi.org/10.1525/ctx.2008.7.1.28>.
11. Nazgol Ghandnoosh and Josh Rovner, "Immigration and Public Safety," (Washington, D.C.: The Sentencing Project, 2017), <https://www.sentencingproject.org/app/uploads/2022/10/Immigration-and-Public-Safety.pdf>, 8.
12. "Debunking the Myth of Immigrants and Crime," Fact Sheet (Washington, D.C.: American Immigration Council, October 2024), https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/sites/default/files/research/debunking_the_myth_of_immigrants_and_crime.pdf, 2.
13. Hanna Love, "Want to Reduce Violence? Invest in Place," (Washington, D.C.: Brookings Institute, November 16, 2021), <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/want-to-reduce-violence-invest-in-place>. See also Scott A. Desmond and Charis E. Kubrin, "The Power of Place: Immigrant Communities and Adolescent Violence," *The Sociological Quarterly* 50, no. 4 (September 1, 2009): 581–607, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1533-8525.2009.01153.x>; Ariel G. Ruiz Soto, "Explainer: Immigrants and Crime in the United States," Explainers. (Washington, D.C.: Migration Policy Institute, October 2024), <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/content/immigrants-and-crime>.
14. Melissa Marino, "Profile of Robert J. Sampson," *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 105, no. 3 (2008): 842–44, <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.0711294105>.
15. Robert J. Sampson et al., "Neighborhoods and Violent Crime: A Multilevel Study of Collective Efficacy," *Science*, New Series 277, no. 5328 (1997): 918–24.
16. According to the World Migration Report, "Defining [...] 'social cohesion' is a difficult task, as there are no universally recognized definitions." However, the report notes that, "[i]n broad terms, social cohesion can be defined through the notions of 'solidarity,' 'togetherness,' 'tolerance,' and 'harmonious co-existence.'" Céline Bauloz, Zana Vathi, and Diego Acosta, "Migration, Inclusion, and Social Cohesion: Challenges, Recent Developments, and Opportunities," in *World Migration Report 2020* (International Organization for Migration, 2019), 167–210, <https://doi.org/10.1002/wom3.16>. See also "UNICEF Working Paper: Family Unity in the Context of Migration," Working Paper (UNICEF), accessed June 30, 2025, <https://www.unicef.org/media/58341/file/Family%20unity%20issue%20brief.pdf>.
17. Desmond and Kubrin, "The Power of Place"; Ben Feldmeyer et al., "Immigration, Collective Efficacy, Social Ties, and Violence: Unpacking the Mediating Mechanisms in Immigration Effects on Neighborhood-Level Violence," *Race and Justice* 9, no. 2 (April 2019): 123–50, <https://doi.org/10.1177/2153368717690563>; Zoya Gubernskaya and Joanna Dreby, "US Immigration Policy and the Case for Family Unity," *Journal on Migration and Human Security* 5, no. 2 (2017): 417–30, <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/233150241700500210>; Charis E. Kubrin, John R. Hipp, and Young-An Kim, "Different than the Sum of Its Parts: Examining the Unique Impacts of Immigrant Groups on Neighborhood Crime Rates," *Journal of Quantitative Criminology* 34, no. 1 (March 2018): 1–36, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10940-016-9320-y>; Alejandro Portes and Rubén G. Rumbaut, *Immigrant America: A Portrait*, 3rd ed. (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006); Manuela

- Orjuela-Grimm et al., “Household Composition after Resettlement and Emotional Health in Adolescent Migrants,” *Journal of Migration and Health* 5 (January 1, 2022): 100103, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jmh.2022.100103>.
18. “The Advantages of Family-Based Immigration,” Fact Sheet (Washington, D.C: American Immigration Council, March 2013), https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/sites/default/files/research/fact_sheet_on_family_immigration_0.pdf; Zoya Gubernskaya and Joanna Dreby, “US Immigration Policy and the Case for Family Unity,”; Portes and Rumbaut, *Immigrant America*.
19. “The Advantages of Family-Based Immigration”; Gubernskaya and Dreby, “US Immigration Policy and the Case for Family Unity.”
20. Desmond and Kubrin, “The Power of Place”; Feldmeyer et al., “Immigration, Collective Efficacy, Social Ties, and Violence”; Kubrin, Hipp, and Kim, “Different than the Sum of Its Parts”; Graham C. Ousey and Charis E. Kubrin, “Exploring the Connection between Immigration and Violent Crime Rates in U.S. Cities, 1980–2000,” *Social Problems* 56, no. 3 (August 2009): 447–73, <https://doi.org/10.1525/sp.2009.56.3.447>; Portes and Rumbaut, *Immigrant America*; Alejandro Portes and Min Zhou, “The New Second Generation: Segmented Assimilation and Its Variants,” *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 530, no. 1 (November 1, 1993): 74–96, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0002716293530001006>.
21. Jeremy Hein, *Ethnic Origins: The Adaptation of Cambodian and Hmong Refugees in Four American Cities*. (New York: Russell Sage Foundation, 2006).
22. “Refugee and Migrant Mental Health,” Fact Sheet (Geneva, Switzerland: World Health Organization, May 6, 2025), <https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/refugee-and-migrant-mental-health>.
23. Gubernskaya and Dreby, “US Immigration Policy and the Case for Family Unity.”
24. “Refugee and Migrant Mental Health.”
25. Gubernskaya and Dreby, “US Immigration Policy and the Case for Family Unity.”
26. Brittany N. Morey et. al., “The Central Role of Social Support in the Health of Chinese and Korean American Immigrants,” *Social Science & Medicine* 284 (September 2021): 114229, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2021.114229>.
27. “Promoting Integration through Social Connections,” Integration Handbook (Geneva, Switzerland: United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, March 9, 2024), <https://www.unhcr.org/handbooks/ih/social-connections/promoting-integration-through-social-connections>.